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Introduction: Art and Catharsis

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Nearly two decades ago, sociologist Barbara Rosenblum (1978) observed that by avoiding analysis of the content of art, scholars unnecessarily circumscribe understanding of the interrelationship of art and the social and political organization of society. Through such works as Balfe's (1979) analysis of the qualities of medieval Madonnas in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, we have learned that the politicized image of maternity was a resource that political elites strove to control, while its aesthetic qualities, in turn, influenced the distribution of social power. But most social scientists concerned about maintaining the "separateness" or autonomy of aesthetics in its contribution to the social production and construction of art have traditionally avoided analysis of aesthetics and its relationship to social structure: They have neglected the social construction of meaning that is derived from aesthetic qualities and the contribution of that meaning to the social organization of society (Bowler 1994). As Wolfe (1992, 707) notes, this narrow vision ignores the fact that "far from reflecting the already-given world, . . . cultural forms participate in the production of that world."

Contemporary social criticism about the consequences of modernity often focuses on the impact of rationality, science, technology, and expertise on the social construction of social, political, and economic power. What often follows is the presumption by social critics that contemporary society has all but eliminated a place for affect and emotion in daily life, has curiously distorted or transformed it, or has at least rearranged its location and how we partake in it, both individually and collectively (Giddens 1991; Scheff 1979; Klapp 1969). Connections between art and catharsis are readily observed at the soci-

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etal level: Collective memory, public art, and public monuments are accessible examples. But we know very little about the foundational contribution of processes whereby subjectivity, ethnicity, time, memory, and emotion contribute to the social production of art. This theme issue of *JAMLS*, which explores the relationship between art and catharsis as part of aesthetic systems, extends Rosenblum's concerns about the social production of art content to include the social construction of the emotional processes through which art objects are produced. How is catharsis incorporated into artistic content and artistic production?

Traditionally, catharsis is defined as the "emotional discharge" that accompanies the experience of distressful emotions, but a broader view of catharsis is needed to explore it as a component of aesthetic systems. Artistic intentionality, including catharsis, resides in the execution of an artist's work, but an artist's "charge" or "brief" is shaped by social factors (Baxandall 1985; Griswold 1987). Social and practical elements, constraints, and influences affect subjectivity at the time of production, determining the extent to which the artist's intention is fulfilled. How artists' catharsis interacts with the conditions of production and influences the content of art is the subject of this issue.

The authors of the articles in this issue on art and catharsis were participants in the Twenty-first Annual Conference on Social Theory, Politics, and the Arts held at the University of California, Santa Barbara, in October 1995. Tina Takemoto addresses how illness, gender, and race intersect to frame artistic performance. Elizabeth A. Brown explores the application of catharsis to vanguard art, in particular the signification of emotion in the work of contemporary artists Lari Pittman and Kiki Smith. Britta B. Wheeler enters the world of performance artists and examines the relationship between audience catharsis and catharsis as content in performance art works. Through access to Death Row inmates in a prison facility located in the southwestern United States, C. Lee Harrington examines how the subjective redefinition of time, which is simultaneously endless (due to incarceration) and compressed (because of a death sentence), defines the way inmates produce crafts as art. Finally, Jacqueline A. Gibbons addresses ways that stigma intersects with gender and race and precipitates creative expression in an Australian women's prison. Collectively, the articles in this issue provide a tantalizing look at the emotional contours of artistic creativity and production and invite us to incorporate the authors' insights into our own work on art and society.

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